

Scripts for X-ray postprocessing with USPEX

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1 Introduction

In this document I present a series of Python scripts used to postprocess the results of USPEX calculations when working with experimental X-ray diffraction data. The core of this collection of scripts is constituted by the scripts `powder_xrd_screening.py` and `scxrd_screening.py`, which allow the user to quickly sort a number of structures read from the USPEX output according to their degree of agreement with experimental X-ray data. The first script works with powder XRD data, while the second script works with single crystal XRD data. Both scripts can be used not only with USPEX output files, but also with any set of structures in the POSCAR format, for example, with structures taken from a database. The theory beyond the functioning of these two scripts is illustrated in appendices A and B.

The first 3 scripts take in input a number of files written by USPEX, while the remaining scripts work with structural information contained in CIF or POSCAR files. All script take in input some information about the experimental X-ray data as well. At the time of writing this document, the collection of scripts has been tested on the following Python versions: 3.6, 3.7, 3.8, 3.13.

2 `split_CIFs.py`

It splits the structures with lowest enthalpy of a variable composition USPEX run into multiple CIF files. The script takes the following arguments from command line:

1. the output file `extended_convex_hull` from USPEX
2. the output file `extended_convex_hull_POSCARS` from USPEX
3. the value of the external pressure used for the USPEX run

The script performs the following operations:

1. for each structure, it reads the parameters *enthalpy* and *fitness* from `extended_convex_hull` and the geometry from `extended_convex_hull_POSCARS`

2. it selects, for each reduced formula, the 5 structures with lowest enthalpy
3. it outputs the selected structures as CIF files in a new folder *results*

The name of each CIF file has the format `i_ID.fitness.enthalpy.iupacformula.pressure.symmetry.cif`, where:

- i** is a natural number which orders the output with increasing *fitness*
- ID** is the structure ID from the USPEX run
- fitness** is the *fitness* of the structure
- enthalpy** is the *enthalpy* of the structure
- iupacformula** is the *IUPAC formula* of the structure
- pressure** is the pressure used for the USPEX run
- symmetry** is the space group number, determined with tolerance 0.2 Å

Example: `python split_CIFs.py extended_convex_hull
extended_convex_hull_POSCARS 50GPa`

3 sublattice_split_CIFs.py

It reads the results of a variable composition USPEX run, it removes all hydrogen atoms, and then it splits the structures with lowest enthalpy into multiple CIF files. The script takes the following arguments from command line:

1. the output file `extended_convex_hull` from USPEX
2. the output file `extended_convex_hull_POSCARS` from USPEX
3. the value of the external pressure used for the USPEX run

The script performs the following operations:

1. for each structure, it reads the parameters *enthalpy* and *fitness* from `extended_convex_hull` and the geometry from `extended_convex_hull_POSCARS`
2. it deletes all hydrogen atoms
3. it selects, for each reduced formula, the 5 structures with lowest enthalpy
4. it outputs the selected structures as CIF files in a new folder *results*

The name of each CIF file has the format `i_ID.fitness.enthalpy.iupacformula.pressure.symmetry.cif`, where:

- i** is a natural number which orders the output with increasing *fitness*
- ID** is the structure ID from the USPEX run

fitness is the *fitness* of the structure

enthalpy is the *enthalpy* of the structure

iupacformula is the *IUPAC formula* of the structure, with hydrogens

pressure is the pressure used for the USPEX run

symmetry is the space group number, determined with a tolerance of 0.2 Å and without hydrogens

Example: `python sublattice_split_CIFs.py extended_convex_hull
extended_convex_hull_POSCARS 50GPa`

4 fixcomp_split_CIFs.py

It splits all the structures of a fixed composition USPEX run into multiple CIF files. The script takes the following arguments from command line:

1. the output file **Individuals** from USPEX
2. the output file **gatheredPOSCARS** from USPEX
3. the value of the external pressure used for the USPEX run

The script performs the following operations:

1. for each structure, it reads the parameter *enthalpy* from **Individuals** and the geometry from **gatheredPOSCARS**
2. it computes `real_fitness = enthalpy / total_number_of_atoms`
3. it outputs the structures as CIF files in a new folder *results*

The name of each CIF file has the format `i_ID_fitness_enthalpy_iupacformula_pressure_symmetry.cif`, where:

i is a natural number which orders the output with increasing `real_fitness`

ID is the structure ID from the USPEX run

fitness is the `real_fitness` of the structure

enthalpy is the *enthalpy* of the structure

iupacformula is the *IUPAC formula* of the structure

pressure is the pressure used for the USPEX run

symmetry is the space group number, determined with a tolerance of 0.2 Å

Example: `python fixcomp_split_CIFs.py Individuals gatheredPOSCARS
50GPa`

5 powder_xrd_screening.py

The script screens a collection of structures to identify those that best match an experimental powder X-ray diffraction pattern. For the theory behind this script, see appendix A. In a few words, given an experimental pattern in input, the theoretical diffraction pattern is calculated for each candidate structure and a value F is computed. The smaller is F , the better is the agreement between theoretical and experimental patterns. The script contains the following input parameters:

1. the name of the file `gathered.POSCARS`, which is a collection of crystal structures in the POSCAR format
2. the name of the *spectrum file*, containing angles and intensities of the experimental powder diffraction pattern
3. the start and end angles for the computation of theoretical diffraction patterns
4. an array of coefficients k for performing isotropic deformations of the unit cell for all crystal structures
5. the value of σ for the Gaussian smearing of peaks, used for generating output pictures
6. the experimental wavelength
7. the parameter *match_tol*, that is the tolerance for matching experimental peaks with theoretical peaks, in degrees
8. the parameter *th_peaks_penalty*, which controls the additional penalty given to non-matching theoretical peaks in our fitness function

The script performs the following operations:

1. for each structure, it reads the geometry from `gathered.POSCARS`
2. for each given value of k , it performs an isotropic deformation of the unit cell by multiplying each lattice parameter by k
3. it computes the theoretical X-ray diffraction pattern of the so-obtained structure
4. it computes the disagreement F between theoretical and experimental diffraction patterns using our fitness function
5. for each structure and for the lowest value of F across all the coefficients k , it outputs a CIF file with the symmetrized structure (tolerance 0.2 Å)
6. for each structure and for the lowest value of F across all the coefficients k , it outputs a PNG graph with the theoretical and experimental diffraction patterns superimposed for comparison

7. for each structure, it outputs a PNG graph which shows the variation of F with k

The name of each CIF and PNG file have the format `F_ID.iupacformula.k_symmetry`, where:

F is the disagreement F between theoretical and experimental diffraction patterns

ID is the comment provided in the first line of each POSCAR (if the POSCAR file is produced by USPEX, this is the structure ID in the USPEX run)

iupacformula is the *IUPAC formula* of the structure

k is the value of the coefficient k which gave the lowest disagreement F

symmetry is the space group number, determined with a tolerance of 0.2 Å

Example: `python powder_xrd_screening.py`

6 scxrd_screening.py

This script performs a screening of USPEX results, looking for the structures that best match an experimental single crystal X-ray spectrum. The fitness function for evaluating the agreement between theoretical and experimental spectra is the weighted R-factor (see appendix B). Notice that the USPEX run must have been performed at fixed cell parameters. The script contains the following input parameters:

1. the name of the `gatheredPOSCARS` file from the USPEX run
2. the name of the HKL file containing experimental reflections

The script outputs a file `results.txt` which contains a list of ordered structure IDs with their relative weighted R-factor, from the most fit to the least fit.

Example: `python scxrd_screening.py`

7 pareto_picture.py

This script organizes and visualizes the results of a USPEX calculation in which multi-objective optimization of stability together with the agreement with an experimental powder XRD spectrum has been optimized. Lines 19-21 of the script contain the input parameters, which need to be tuned by the user:

1. the wavelength of the incident radiation in Å
2. the name of the working directory, which must contain the files `goodStructures` and `goodStructures_POSCARS` from the USPEX output, as well as the spectrum file

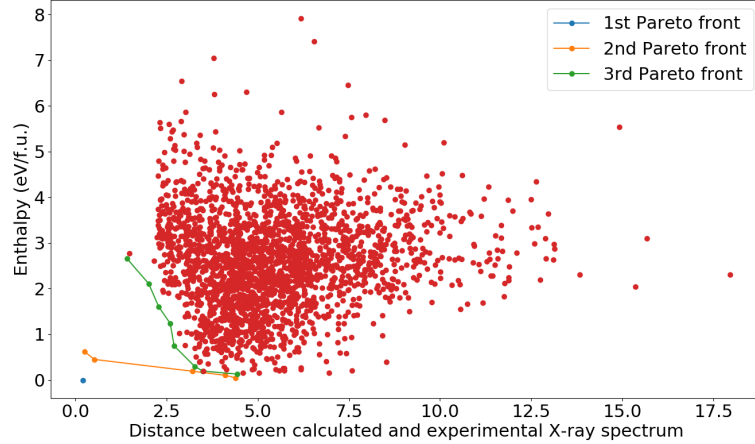


Figure 1: Graph produced by the script `pareto_picture.png` from the results of an USPEX run in which stability of the system $\text{K}_4\text{Ta}_4\text{W}_4\text{O}_{24}$ has been optimized together with the agreement with an experimental powder XRD spectrum.

3. the name of the spectrum file

The output of the script is constituted by a picture, named `pareto.png`, displaying each structure on a plane where stability lies on the Y axis and the disagreement with the given spectrum lies on the X axis (see Fig. 1). On the picture, the first three Pareto fronts are shown. It is possible to focus on a specific area of the graph by specifying the intervals to display on the X and Y axes at lines 76-77 and by rerunning the script. In addition, the scripts creates a folder named `pareto_fronts` which contains, for each structure on the first three Pareto fronts, a structure file in the POSCAR format and a picture which visually compares the predicted powder XRD spectrum of the structure with the given spectrum contained in the spectrum file, as in Fig. 2. The name of these files have the format `rank_F_enthalpy_ID`, where:

rank is the progressive number of the Pareto front

F is the agreement F between simulated and given spectra

enthalpy is the enthalpy of the structure

ID is the structure ID from the USPEX run

Example: `python pareto_picture.py`

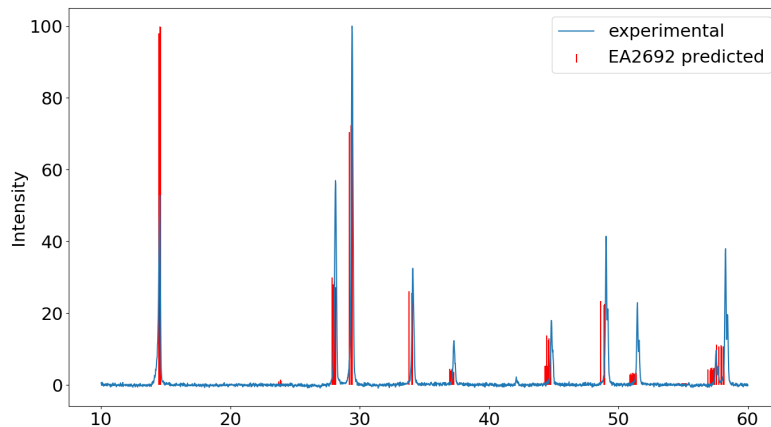


Figure 2: Graph produced by the script `pareto_picture.png` from the results of an USPEX run in which stability of the system $\text{K}_4\text{Ta}_4\text{W}_4\text{O}_{24}$ has been optimized together with the agreement with an experimental powder XRD spectrum.

8 exclusion.py

It allows to quickly filter a multitude of CIF files, by removing those which have significant peaks in a user-defined exclusion region of the X-ray spectrum. The script takes the following arguments from command line:

1. the wavelength of the incident radiation in Å
2. the peak cut-off, in % of the maximum intensity
3. a number of intervals in degrees, expressed as two angles separated by a hyphen (-), defining the exclusion region

The script works in a folder with many CIF files, and performs the following:

1. it opens, one by one, all CIF files and it predicts the XRD pattern of the structure according to the given wavelength
2. if the predicted pattern contains any peak in the exclusion regions that is bigger than the given cut-off, it deletes the CIF file

Example: `python exclusion.py 0.6199 25 25-28 31-32`

9 find_peak.py

It allows to quickly filter a multitude of CIF files, by removing those which do not have significant peaks in all user-defined search intervals of the X-ray

spectrum. The script takes the following arguments from command line:

1. the wavelength of the incident radiation in Å
2. the peak cut-off, in % of the maximum intensity
3. a number of search intervals in degrees, expressed as two angles separated by a hyphen (-)

The script works in a folder with many CIF files, and performs the following:

1. it opens, one by one, all CIF files and it predicts the XRD pattern of the structure according to the given wavelength
2. if there is at least one search region which does not contain any peak bigger than the given cut-off, it deletes the CIF file

Example: `python find_peak.py 0.6199 15 25-28 31-32`

10 `change_pressure.py`

It translates the structures contained in many CIF files to a different pressure, by deforming the lattice parameters using a second order Taylor expansion of the Birch-Murnaghan equation. More details about the underlying theory can be found in appendix A. The script takes the following arguments from command line:

1. the initial pressure
2. the final pressure

The script works in a folder with many CIF files, and performs the following:

1. it reads the structures contained in all CIF files
2. it deforms the lattice parameters according to the new pressure
3. it creates new CIF files containing the deformed structures

The name of the new CIF files have the format `OLDNAME_toNEWPRESSURE`, where:

OLDNAME is the name of the file with the structure at the initial pressure

NEWPRESSURE is the final pressure

Example: `python change_pressure.py 50 58`

11 relax_new_pressure.py

It allows an accurate translation of the structures contained in many CIF files to a different pressure, by relaxing them with VASP. The script works in a folder with many CIF files and it is meant to be run on a cluster. Before running it, add the following lines to your `.bashrc` file:

1. `export VASP_SCRIPT=PATH/TO/relax_new_pressure/run_vasp.py`
2. `export VASP_PP_PATH=PATH/TO/YOUR/pp/FOLDER`

Then tune the `relax_new_pressure.py` file with the desired new pressure and the appropriate VASP parameters for your calculation and run the python script on a computing node. By default, VASP relaxations are performed sequentially and every relaxation takes 4 computing cores. For more details about the implementation, have a look at the ASE VASP calculator.

12 single_plot.py

This simple script is used to obtain a plot of the predicted powder XRD spectrum of a single structure against the experimental spectrum. It takes in input, at lines 12-14, the following three parameters:

1. the wavelength of the incident radiation in Å
2. the name of the file containing the geometry of the structure in POSCAR format
3. the name of the file containing the experimental spectrum

Example: `python single_plot.py`

Example: `python scxrd_screening.py`

Appendices

A Powder spectra comparison

We developed a code which computes, from the experimental powder XRD spectrum and the USPEX output, the degree of disagreement (fitness) of each relaxed structure with the experimental data. The USPEX calculation and the experimental spectrum do not need to be exactly at the same pressure, but the two pressures need to be *close*, that is, no more than 20 GPa apart.

Since we have a pressure difference, we first translate each calculated structure to the experimental pressure using the Birch-Murnaghan equation

$$\Delta P = \frac{3B_0}{2} \left[\left(\frac{V_0}{V} \right)^{\frac{7}{3}} - \left(\frac{V_0}{V} \right)^{\frac{5}{3}} \right] \left\{ 1 + \frac{3}{4} (B'_0 - 4) \left[\left(\frac{V_0}{V} \right)^{\frac{2}{3}} - 1 \right] \right\}$$

where ΔP is the pressure difference, V_0 is the volume of the unit cell at the calculated pressure, V is the volume at the experimental pressure, B_0 is the bulk modulus and B'_0 is the derivative of the bulk modulus with respect to pressure. The parameters B_0 and B'_0 are user-defined and, if not explicitly specified, they default to the average values $B_0 = 300$ and $B'_0 = 3$.

Assuming that, for small pressure variations, V_0/V will be close to 1, we approximate the Birch-Murnaghan equation to a second order Taylor expansion in V_0/V and we get the volume V at the experimental pressure:

$$V = \frac{B_0(B'_0 - 1)}{B_0(B'_0 - 2) + \sqrt{B_0^2 + 2B_0(B'_0 - 1)\Delta P}} V_0$$

Then we define the following scaling factor

$$k = \sqrt[3]{\frac{B_0(B'_0 - 1)}{B_0(B'_0 - 2) + \sqrt{B_0^2 + 2B_0(B'_0 - 1)\Delta P}}}$$

that will be used to rescale the lattice parameters of all the calculated structures. After this rescaling, the relaxed structures are symmetrized with a tolerance of 0.2 Å and the theoretical XRD spectra are computed. Both the theoretical and the experimental spectra are in the form of a series of peaks.

In the case of powder XRD spectra, for each peak we know the diffraction angle and the relative intensity, while the intensity of the highest peak in each spectrum has been conventionally given the value 100. We define a *match* between a theoretical and an experimental peak the case when the two peaks are less than *match_tol* degrees apart, regardless of their intensities. The fitness between a calculated powder XRD spectrum and the experimental spectrum is defined by the following fitness function

$$F = \sum_{i,j}^{match} \left(\frac{h_i^{exp} - h_j^{th}}{100} \right)^2 \left(\frac{h_i^{exp}}{100} \right)^2 + \sum_i^{exp rest} \left(\frac{h_i^{exp}}{100} \right)^2 + \sum_i^{th rest} \left(\frac{h_i^{th}}{100} \right)^2$$

where the h_i are diffraction intensities. The first term of the fitness is a sum over the matched peaks, and each addend of this sum will be smaller the more the intensities of the two matched peaks are close to each other. The second term is a sum over the experimental peaks that are left after our matching, we call these peaks *experimental rest*. The third term, analogously, is a sum over the *theoretical rest*. It is clear that a low value of F gives a good agreement between calculated and experimental powder XRD spectra, allowing a quick identification of promising candidates in the USPEX output.

B Single crystal spectra comparison

In the case of single crystal XRD spectra, for each reflection we know the Miller indices (h, k, l) , its intensity I and its uncertainty of measure σ . As fitness we use the weighted R-factor, given by

$$wR = \sqrt{\frac{\sum \frac{1}{\sigma^2} (I_{exp} - I_{th})^2}{\sum \frac{1}{\sigma^2} I_{exp}^2}}$$

where the sums run over all the experimental reflections and theoretical reflections at the same Miller indices (h, k, l) . If an experimental reflection is not matched by any theoretical reflection an error is returned, while in the opposite case the unmatched theoretical reflection is simply ignored.